The monsoon may be on the wane, but it's still raining freebies across the country. With the Aam Aadmi Party attempting to make inroads into Narendra Modi and Bharatiya Janata Party bastion Gujarat, AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal is pulling out all the stops to woo the electorate. The Delhi chief minister is following the template he honed to perfection to win first the national capital, and more recently Punjab, by a landslide. Among the generous doles he has promised the Gujarat voter are free electricity of up to 300 units a month, a Rs 1,000 monthly allowance for all women above 18, the guarantee of a job to every youth and, until then, a monthly unemployment dole of Rs 3,000.

Kejriwal is not the only one to unabashedly announce what he calls welfare measures but what the prime minister has been denouncing as the *revdi* (a sesame-coated sweet rock candy distributed free during festivals) or freebie culture for a while now. Few, for example, can beat Jagan Mohan Reddy, the chief minister of Andhra Pradesh, who has launched a number of welfare schemes since coming to power in 2019 on the back of such announcements. So the mother of a student gets financial aid of Rs 15,000 to encourage parents to send their children to school, farmers receive free or concessional power supply or cash transfers and every farmer gets annual financial assistance of Rs 7,500, self-owned taxi and auto drivers Rs 24,000 and every handloom-owning weaver family Rs 10,000. The largesse will cost the state Rs 27,451 crore—2.1 per cent of its GSDP (gross state domestic product)—threatening to significantly slow down the state's economic growth rate.

And lest you think that only Opposition-ruled states indulge their voters, there's Madhya Pradesh, where the Shivraj Singh Chouhan-led BJP government this year will bear the expense of Rs 21,000 crore, or 1.6 per cent of its GSDP, to subsidise electricity to both farmers and domestic users. In Uttar Pradesh, Yogi

SPEND

WEST BENGAL

ELECTRICITY

Free for those consuming 75 units quarterly (annual cost: Rs 5,103 crore)

DEVICES

Tablets Rs 10,000 to be transferred to bank accounts of govt school/ madrassa students for tablets. To benefit 950,000 Class 12 students

Smartphones Rs 8,000 to ASHA workers and girls to purchase smartphones

FINANCIAL ASSISTANCE

Pensions: Rs 1,000 for senior citizens of SC/ ST communities. Expected cost: Rs 3,000 crore

Kanyashree Rs 1,648 crore for 7.8 mn schoolgoing girls

Lakshmir Bhandar Rs 17,000 crore for 15 million poor women (25-60 age group)

Swasthyasathi Rs 2,500 crore for health cover to 20 mn families

Krishak Bandhu Rs 3,000 crore as assured benefit to help 7 mn farmers

Education loans Rs 54 cr) spent so far, with 14,000 availing the Rs 10 lakh student loans for higher studies

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

ANDHRA PRADESH

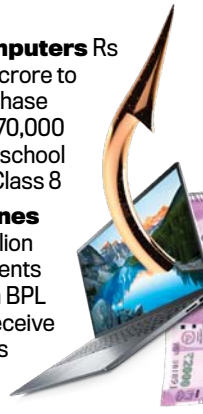
ELECTRICITY

Nine hours of free power per day to 1.8 million farmers (Rs 8,559 crore in 2020-21)

DEVICES

Computers Rs 500 crore to purchase tablets for 470,000 government school students in Class 8

Smartphones 6 million students from BPL families to receive smartphones under a 2022-23 scheme



FINANCIAL ASSISTANCE

In 2021-22, the state transferred Rs 55,000 crore to beneficiaries through direct benefit transfer (DBT) schemes, with Rs 17,305 crore more spent on non-DBT schemes

MADHYA PRADESH

ELECTRICITY

Consumers using up to 100 units are charged only Rs 100. The annual bill for this is Rs 5,000 crore

FINANCIAL ASSISTANCE

Farm support In 2019, the state waived Rs 7,154 crore worth of loans taken by about 2 million small farmers